

ABC Asks a Judge to Stop an Early Check of Its TV Licenses

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TV stations need a **license** from the government to send out their shows over the air. A group called the Federal Communications Commission, or FCC, gives out these **licenses**.

In April, FCC Commissioner Brendan Carr told eight ABC stations to apply to **renew** their **licenses** years early. The Associated Press says this came just after a joke by ABC host Jimmy Kimmel made President Donald Trump angry.

ABC and its owner, Disney, **sued** the FCC in August. ABC says the early check breaks the **First Amendment**, which protects free speech. It says it is being punished for shows the president does not like.

On Tuesday, ABC asked Judge Loren AliKhan to stop the review. A government lawyer said the case belongs in a different court. He said ABC's **licenses** are still **valid**.

The judge did not decide yet. A ruling is not expected until at least mid-October.

Word Treasure

license -- A paper from the government that says you are allowed to do something.

renew -- To make something last longer, like getting a new card when an old one runs out.

sued -- Took someone to court to ask a judge to settle a problem.

First Amendment -- The part of the U.S. Constitution that protects free speech.

valid -- Still official and allowed to be used.

Background you need

TV stations send shows through the air using signals that belong to the public, so they need permission from the government.

The FCC is the government group that gives out this permission, called a license.

The First Amendment protects free speech, so the government is not supposed to punish people for what they say.

Break it down

WHO: ABC and Disney versus the FCC, with Judge Loren AliKhan deciding

WHAT: ABC asked the judge to stop an early check of its TV station licenses

WHERE: A federal court

WHY: ABC says it is being punished for shows the president does not like, which it says breaks free speech

Why it matters

Free speech rules protect the shows and news you watch from being punished just because a leader dislikes them.

Test what you remember

1. What group gives out TV station licenses?
 - ☐ (A) NASA
 - ☐ (B) The FCC
 - ☐ (C) Disney
 - ☐ (D) The FBI
2. How many ABC stations were told to renew early?
 - ☐ (A) One
 - ☐ (B) Three
 - ☐ (C) Eight
 - ☐ (D) Twenty
3. Who owns ABC?
 - ☐ (A) The Associated Press
 - ☐ (B) Netflix
 - ☐ (C) The FCC
 - ☐ (D) Disney
4. What does ABC say the early check breaks?
 - ☐ (A) A sports rule
 - ☐ (B) A school rule
 - ☐ (C) The First Amendment
 - ☐ (D) A traffic law
5. What did a government lawyer say about ABC's licenses?
 - ☐ (A) They were never real
 - ☐ (B) They are still valid
 - ☐ (C) They are for radio only
 - ☐ (D) They were taken away
6. When is a ruling expected?
 - ☐ (A) Never
 - ☐ (B) It already happened
 - ☐ (C) Not until at least mid-October
 - ☐ (D) In five years

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: C 3: D 4: C 5: B 6: C

Questions to think about

1. **ABC:** Says the early check breaks the First Amendment and punishes it for shows the president does not like.
2. **Government lawyer:** Says the case belongs in a different court and ABC's licenses are still valid.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):